

Solidarity and Disruption

Collective Organizing In Computing II

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ABSTRACT

This workshop responds to the incredible growth of corporate tech power - including during a deadly pandemic - and the growing need for tech workers of all stripes (including researchers/academics) to build grassroots power. This workshop's twinned themes of solidarity and disruption acknowledge that solidarity is vital but not sufficient to enact the structural changes we need. Disruption—in the form of sit-ins, strikes, refusal, and direct action—has become a necessary condition in the face of technology corporations' greed-driven expansion towards militaristic, techno-totalitarian futures. In this one-day workshop, we will bring together tech workers, researchers and activists from academia, industry, and community-based organizations to extend conversations that we began in two workshops last year. We will further explore avenues and approaches for action, particularly to support practitioners' and activists' objectives, and connect participants with concrete opportunities for *on-the-ground* action.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → **Computer supported cooperative work**; • **Social and professional topics** → *Computing profession*;

KEYWORDS

solidarity, disruption, tech worker, activism, organizing

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1 BACKGROUND

“Solidarity Not Charity” has been a cry of tech workers and mutual aid movements during the pandemic [17]. Solidarity as a concept is easy to grasp, endlessly pursued in practice: to find a sense of common cause toward shared struggles. Recent work in CSCW has taken up solidarity [10] as a way to think about our position as researchers as we seek to address ongoing questions of social justice [11, 12], worker-centered design [13, 15] and people who are at the margins of CSCW and technology design [8, 9, 19]. In our own community, solidarity has become less “academic” following the firing of top members of Google’s Ethical AI team [18] and the calls for ACM to respond to and address issues of systemic racism within the Association [14]. These events have highlighted solidarity as vital for those navigating dual positions, both as researchers whose work is implicated in the conditions of the tech industry, but who are ourselves tech workers too.

We are a collective of researchers who have been taking up questions of social responsibility and collective action in the contexts of the societal impacts of technology and our own workplaces. Over the last two years we have asked ourselves how to connect the challenges we see in our research and institutions. In 2020, we hosted two workshops, at PDC ‘20 [6] and CSCW ‘20 [16], and in 2021 we wrote a report on the need to invest in community technology to counteract *Big Tech* [5] and held an ‘ACM Strike School’ roving workshop series to address these themes. As we continue to experiment with approaches to these conversations, especially over the preceding two years of reconfigured workplaces and (research) academics, we are also motivated to deepen conversations on our social responsibility and ethical obligation for collective action at CSCW.

2 WORKSHOP THEMES

The two themes of our workshop are “*solidarity*” and “*disruption*.” These themes are linked together in acknowledgment that solidarity alone is not sufficient. We reject the corporate, profit-seeking definition of “disruption,” and reclaim the collective disruptions of sit-ins, strikes, refusal, and direct action. These latter tactics have become necessary in the face of technology corporations’ greed-driven expansion towards militaristic, techno-totalitarian futures. We are buoyed by Google and Microsoft employees’ protests against developing technology for the US military [1, 7]. Yet the question remains: as technologists and knowledge workers, how can we build solidarity and *mobilize* that solidarity to disrupt the activities of corporations, and even our own institutions?

We have taken incremental steps to build solidarity and pathways to disruption through our previous workshops [6, 16]. Our previous workshop highlighted that there is growing interest within the CSCW community in supporting each other in meaningful ways across our various workplaces and contexts (as graduate student workers, researchers, and industry practitioners). We concluded that workshop with our intention to help each other “understand our relationship to power as mediated by tech, the tech industry, and academia.” Additionally, the work we have done as a collective over the past year — including hosting multiple strike school workshops — signals to us that there is significant interest in learning more of the concrete tools of organizing and disruption (e.g., building relationships, power mapping, and organizing a campaign). We see these as necessary in pushing for structural changes that our research agendas — as “participatory” or “inclusive” as they may be — cannot reach.

The past year since our last CSCW workshop has only made the necessity of solidarity and disruption more apparent. On the back of a deadly global pandemic, technology corporations have enriched and entrenched themselves to staggering levels. From March 2020 to March 2021, Jeff Bezos’s personal wealth increased to \$178 billion from \$113 billion as Amazon waged a brutal anti-union campaign in Bessemer, Alabama [4]. And, as the Palestinian people were once again besieged by Israeli warplanes in late May 2021, the Biden administration approved a \$735 million sale of Boeing weapons to Israel, which is only a portion of the \$3.8 billion of U.S. military aid the country receives annually [2, 3]. Boeing has claimed that their “innovative” technologies are designed to be “user-centered,” thus deploying tech industry (and HCI/CSCW) buzzwords to obscure war crimes and attract new talent from computer science and engineering colleges and universities around the world. As researchers and students (who are often in, or adjacent to, these same colleges), the question becomes: “While supporting each other and our work is an important endeavor, how do we take a stand and say that some work should *stop*?” In other words, we intend for our workshop to feature honest and supportive discussions about working in *solidarity* with one another while *disrupting* the status quo that makes us complicit in surveillance, oppression, inequity, environmental disasters, and war and destruction.

Table 1: Overview of proposed activities and timing on the day of the workshop

Activity	Duration
Presentation of participant submissions	1 hour
Small group discussion/ community-building activity	1 hour
Short talks by invited speakers	0.5 hour
Discussion with the invited speakers	1 hour
Small group reflections + takeaways	1 hour

3 ACTIVITIES AND GOALS

This workshop continues the work done during the PDC and CSCW conferences in 2020, which focused on bringing a community together and highlighting the importance of social justice and responsibility in computing work across academia, tech workers and professionals and practitioners in ICT sectors. This year’s workshop seeks to continue to build power and strengthen relationships forged in these previous workshops. Specifically, we will facilitate partnerships to support practitioners’ and activists’ objectives, and connect participants with concrete opportunities for *on-the-ground* action and support. Our goal is to continue building collective cohesion and solidarity while using these bonds to strengthen and explore ways to continue disrupting the status quo.

The workshop will feature short presentations and digital exhibits to showcase participants submissions, followed by small group sessions to further cross-connections. We will follow by facilitating group and trust-building activities aimed at further enhancing relationships and a shared sense of community. We will hold a short series of invited talks from practitioners organizing in tech labor, academia, and gig work to spark discussion around their experiences with social justice and responsibility in technology. We also aim to learn from and share strategies with activists who have previously disrupted hiring and talent acquisition for companies profiteering from oppression, both online (e.g., digital picket lines) and in person (e.g., flyering at recruitment events on campus). Further, we intend to put these tactics in the context of longer-term, sustained organizing, which often requires the tools of *solidarity*: 1-on-1 conversations, power mapping, and planning a campaign alongside our peers and allied communities. With these case studies as a foundation, we will hold small-group facilitated themed discussions (3-5 people) in which participants will be invited to identify and reflect on key challenges and other takeaways. Participants will self-select into the discussion groups by theme making connections more intentional. Facilitators will collect insights across each group to store collective knowledge across local efforts, problems, and initiatives.

We will conduct the workshop using video conferencing tools (e.g. BigBlueButton) supported by online collaboration tools (e.g. Miro boards). Participants will be required to submit a contribution in the form of a personal statement, a case study/field update, reflection of current work/practices or challenges/open questions connected to the theme of the workshop. We will encourage submissions in a variety of formats including written, video, pictorial or audio forms. We ask for at least one author per contribution to

attend the workshop. In order to ensure meaningful interaction for all participants, we will cap attendance at around 40 participants.

4 WORKSHOP AUDIENCE

We will invite a diverse pool of participants including on-the-ground organizers and activists, academics, members of industry, and those who are practicing or hope to practice collective organizing. We will recruit with a Call for Participation distributed across social media, mailing lists, and other broad networks by practitioners. The call and the workshop website will outline the motivation for the workshop, its history, the overall agenda as well as the submission requirements, format, and resources.

5 OUTCOMES

- (1) **Solidarity.** We will strive to create as safe a space as possible for participants, and especially those participants with relatively disempowered economic (e.g., grad students) or social (e.g., racialized) positionalities, to share experiences with each other in order to build collective understandings of exploitation and oppression in the tech and academic industries. We will help to create a safer space with a pre-workshop on holding and sharing space open to all but mandatory for White participants and encouraged for cis men of color.
- (2) **Plans for action.** A wrap-up section will focus on next steps, concrete actions all participants can take, and an invitation to the regular meetings of the ACM Strike School planning committee for any who want to join our group and continue the conversations of the day.
- (3) **Submissions compendium.** The “Tech Otherwise” platform¹ is a collective experiment in open-review publishing aimed at providing an outlet for bringing together critical views on technology rooted in field experience, academic work or creative expression. We will solicit workshop contributions in any media, and archive any that we have permission to publish on Tech Otherwise.
- (4) **Compilation of resources.** Workshop organisers and participants will contribute up-to-date resources to a Wiki-like compilation of links and references that has grown over time from past related events.

6 ORGANIZERS

- **Linda Huber** is a Ph.D student at the University of Michigan School of Information. Her research explores platform infrastructures through ethnography and a feminist STS lens.
- **Pedro Reynolds-Cuellar** is a Ph.D student at the Media, Arts and Sciences program at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology. His research focuses on connecting ancestral technology cultures with new methods in design education, practice and activism in the US and Colombia.
- **EunJeong Cheon** is an Assistant Professor in the School of Information Studies at Syracuse University. Her work examines the roles of values in the design of emerging technologies. She is currently working on the future of work with collaborative robots.

- **P M Krafft** is Senior Lecturer at the University of the Arts London’s Creative Computing Institute (CCI). They currently lead the CCI’s master’s programme in Internet Equalities.
- **Christoph Becker** is Associate Professor of Information at the University of Toronto. His research explores critical engagement across the social sciences, engineering and computer sciences to reorient systems design in computing toward the values of sustainability and justice.
- **Danny Spitzberg** is a sociologist and user researcher at Turning Basin Labs. He facilitates worker-led research studies on workplaces and local economies.
- **Aakash Gautam** is an assistant professor at San Francisco State University. His work involves co-designing socio-technical systems to challenge power differences between stakeholders.
- **Maggie Hughes** is a Ph.D. student at the Media, Arts and Sciences program at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology. Her current research examines how practitioners of social technologies such as facilitated dialogue, organizing, and coaching use data and digital platforms.
- **Alex Ahmed** is a software developer at Sassafras Tech Collective, a worker-owned cooperative, and a proud member of the Industrial Workers of the World.

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